

PART 3: THE VILLAGE

The village has existed on the small island for generations, since before the times of the Spellplague, and all that time, the same families have lived there, intermingling such that it is hard to tell one line from another. The ever malignant degeneracy spread through the populace, making them more and more debased until they could barely be called civilized. The villagers turned away from the worship of the gods, and instead offered their prayers to fiends from the Hells; fiends who would trade worship for very real power in the mortal realm. It was just unlucky that the pirate crew of the *Audacity* should choose this overlooked backwater for their redoubt, and they have paid for it for sixty years.

VILLAGE VIGNETTES

As the characters investigate or fortify the island, you do not need to refer to a map, or take too much time keeping track of how much time is spent at one location or another. After meeting with Elisande, who can serve as a guide and tool for you to assist the players, each adventurer or group of adventurers can investigate approximately one place in the late morning, one at midday and one in the afternoon. If an adventurer or group does something particularly brief and there is ample time, you may consider allowing them an additional encounter on the island. Once night falls, they may have plans, but Ixas' attack will preempt that. The characters may move as a group or split up to cover more ground, though danger may come more swiftly to those who are by themselves.

As the adventurers go to each area, they may choose to investigate the NPCs there, search the location, or even look for ways to prepare for the coming attack. Simply run each adventurer or group of adventurers once through a location-centered vignette and determine if the adventurers are meeting up, reapportioning groups, or proceeding on to the next round of investigations. This continues until each adventurer or group of adventurers have investigated three places. If the adventurers stay together, they are able to investigate a total of four places. If a player is concerned about being able to do enough with his or her adventurer, feel free to explain the time abstraction. It is very important to be aware of the amount of time spent in this part of the adventure; allowing the adventurers to investigate too much can cause the adventure to longer than necessary.

The villagers rarely interact with outsiders, and all of them speak an archaic dialect of Common, making them sometimes difficult to understand. All of them, even married couples, share a familial resemblance. They refer to themselves as Folk and non-islanders as Outsides.

ELISANDE

When the characters first arrive on the island, read the following:

Trees block the view of the village from the landing, so your first sight of the village comes as you climb the wooded hill. It is underwhelming. It is little more than a collection of hovels, a barn, and a large centrally located fire pit. Dirty faces and wide eyes stare at you as you exit the rain soaked tree line, before turning away. A grinning girl with wild dirty hair and a pock marked face runs up to you with obvious excitement. "Who might ye be, Outsides?"

Elisande has been waiting for a chance to escape the island for three years since her parents died in a sickness that tormented the village. At first she has hoped the madman would help her, but it was quickly clear that he would be no help—though he is fun to feed or throw stones at. Now that the adventurers have followed him here, there is another chance and she is not about to waste it.

Use the **commoner** statistics at the end of this Part if should you need stats for Elisande. She avoids combat, but will drag unconscious adventurers out of fights and attempt to stabilize them and makes Wisdom (Medicine) checks with a +2 bonus.

ROLEPLAYING ELISANDE

Elisande is a 12-year old orphan human girl, and village troublemaker. She is fascinated with outsiders, having heard tales that there is a land beyond the island that she yearns to visit now that she has no family left alive. She has no knowledge of the village's past beyond folklore, but is happy to show the adventurers around and answer questions hoping they will take her with them when they leave. She has few morals and due to her upbringing, no true concept of right or wrong.

Initially none of the villagers are especially interested in speaking with the adventurers, regardless of what they have to say. They simply stare at them with a mixture of fear and anger. Only Elisande is friendly and eager to speak with them. A successful DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check confirms that her interest and friendship is

genuine, but she clearly wants something from them. She can relate the following about the island, at least as she knows them:

- The island has no name. The folk have lived here since the beginning of time. Outsiders sometimes come, but rarely stay, and the folk do not like them to.
- The island survives primarily by fishing, growing beets, beans, cabbage and onions, husbanding a few goats and for a treat gathering wild raspberries and bitter walnuts. Sometimes, the sea provides things that wash up on the shores of the island.
- The fisher folk do not have an organized religion as the adventurers might understand it. Instead Elisande describes a collection of folk tales and superstitions, often concerning reptilian monsters from below the sea that both provide for the island folk when they are appeased and prey upon them when they are not. She does not believe that there is anything on the island beyond the landing, the village, and the woods. She has been told and believes the woods to be filled with monsters and does not venture far into it.
- She would like to be friends with the adventurers, playing up her lack of family on the island if the Outsiders seem softhearted. She can show them around or introduce them to others. As the day goes on, she asks more and more questions about the outside world and when the adventurers will be leaving, hinting that she might like to go with them when they leave.
- If the adventurers rebuff Elisande, she begins shadowing them, following them from a few yards away. The villagers do not approve of the girl mixing with outsiders to begin with, so any threats or violence towards the girl will bring their wrath down upon them.

OVERVIEW OF THE ISLAND

The island is composed of a number of different locations to explore. With the exception of the Infernal Altar (which can only be found by exploring the woods), all of the locations are immediately obvious upon the adventurers arrival. Elisande points them out to the party as soon as they speak with her.

After the general deception of each location, there is a subsection detailing what Elisande has to say about the location, what NPCs live there, and what might be found by searching the location.

There are thirty seven total villagers on the island,

twelve of which are children. None of the fishermen are at sea today due to the fierce weather.

LANDING

It is in this slightly sheltered portion on the northwestern side of the island that the villagers land their boats, maintain their nets, and dock the ferry raft. The raft and several oar-powered or small single-masted fishing boats have been drug several feet up shore and tied down. There is a shed here filled with mended nets, rope, and other gear for their trade.

Elisande: “Das the landing. It’s where the Folk reaped da sea’s ripe bounty. Course is also weal for swimmin’ when da dayfire rises high.”

Searching. While there is nothing especially incriminating to be found at the landing, there is a wealth of supplies that might be useful in creating traps to defend the village: barrels of fish oil for lanterns, fish hooks, line, rope, and nets might be put to nefarious purposes if the players are so inclined.

NPCs. Until midday passes, Warsh is here with four other men, tying down the boats and preparing for the approaching storm. Warsh has nothing left to say to the adventurers unless directly approached, but the others point to the rising waves and say the monsters beneath the sea are angry.

To convince Warsh to aid the adventurers, see “Rallying the Villagers” below.

HOMES

There are fourteen hovels that are or were home to small families of island fishermen scattered in a rough circle around the fire pit. The doors all face the fire pit and none have windows that face the sea. Four of the homes are no longer inhabited. Their roofs have collapsed and they no longer have doors or shutters.

Elisande: “Dases be homes to the folk. Outsides mussin’ haven homes! Ye not be sleepin’ in the rains do ye? Iffen so, ye not want to be botherin’ the Folk.”

Searching. The inhabited homes will be hard to search with the residents inside, huddled away from the rain. Attempts to speak with the general populace are met with cold stares and unanswered doors. Impertinent adventures will quickly find the villagers reaching for knives.

However, it is easy enough to pick through the three uninhabited hovels. Without any check it is clear that the hovels are made of logs and stone from the island along with a piecemeal of flotsam recovered from the sea:

barrel staves, sail cloth, and broken oars. A successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) locates an odd fetish necklace in the remains of a rotted dresser. Five human teeth are braided into a long lock of brown human hair. Each tooth has symbol of five radial lines emanating from a central point. The fetish radiates both evil and fading magic from the conjuration school. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check suggests the fetish may have once protected the wearer from summoned creatures. A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Religion) check reveals the markings on the fetish are related to the infernals of the Banehold, the Hells associated with a number of evil deities. Its power faded, the fetish no longer functions.

NPCs. Each hovel has 1d4 adults within it and 1d6-1 children. They villagers do their best to ignore the adventurers unless specifically confronted or called forth by Warsh, Ulburto or one of the crones. In general none of them know of the villages past, but they keep the infernal faith alive, believing themselves to be worshipping the ancient creatures of the sea. The fisher folk will follow the will of their leaders, either siding with the adventurers or against them as appropriate.

RUINED HOVEL

This hovel has collapsed in upon itself, leaving only small area where one wall leans against another that is protected from the rain. The villagers house the "madman" here. Empty food bowls and fish bones are scattered about, making it difficult to approach unheard. Any Dexterity (Stealth) check made to sneak up on Verik is made with disadvantage.

Elisande: "Das me house before me mudder and vater were taken by the chill fever. Now wees kept the lunaman there."

Searching. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) locates a loose stone behind which Verik has been hiding his supplies and notes. Under the stone is a sack in which is a small notebook written in Draconic. It details the number of people and their professions along with a sketch of the village, the woods, and the cave housing the infernal altar in the wooded ravine. In addition there is a vial of green dust that smells foul. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check determines that it is ground **greensleep mushroom**, a poisonous fungus that causes lethargy in any who ingest it.

NPCs. If it is morning or midday, Verik the "madman" is present. If it is afternoon or later, he wanders off to sneak some greensleep powder into the evening water

supply the crones are boiling at the fire pit before hiding in the woods in preparation for the attack.

If the adventurers wish to interrogate Verik, he offers the following:

- He twitches a lot and looks around frantically like he hears voices no one else hears.
- He claims to have seen the ghost ship come and his village attacked by undead spirits that walked out of the waves on the back of dracolich that breathed fire and laid waste to his village.
- If asked about the ship, he describes it as a great spectral galleon with the name "Audacity" painted on the bow. He added that last detail after seeing the name painted on flotsam in the barn, hoping it will bring the horror closes to home.
- Verik is a very good liar and spy, sent by Ixas to map out the village, search for likely stores of knowledge, spread fear, and disrupt the defense. A successful DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) check is needed determine that he is playacting his insanity. Even if confronted, he claims that he thought no one would believe what he saw; he thought it might strengthen his story or at least convince others to take him in. He maintains that his story is real. A second successful DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) check reveals this to be a lie.
- If found out, Verik tries to stall for time, giving away as little as possible. He knows Ixas and the rest of the cult is coming. It's only a matter of time before they rescue him.
- If forced to talk by magic or a successful DC 20 Charisma (Intimidate) check, he admits that he was sent by the Cult of the Dragon to locate tomes of lore or other valuables that might lead his master Ixas, a young mage of some power, to locate some long lost artifact. His does not know the exact plan as he has been in the village for a few days, but usually his allies attack in two groups—one at the main entrance to a village and a second smaller group by stealth from the rear.

BARN

The barn is largely empty but for four goats (three female, one male). The goats are as sickly and degenerate as the other residents of the island. One female has an oddly short, stumpy leg while another has the milky eyes of blindness. The male has only one horn. If the adventurers enquire about a place to stay on the island, they are directed to the barn.

Elisande: "Da is the barn. House for yan goats."

Searching. The barn is made from various flotsam washed up from the sea, including the wood from the Audacity's longboat that they used to come ashore. One of the beams inside the barn (found on a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check) has *Audacity* painted on it in badly faded gold paint.

In addition, there are a number of items that may be useful for the defense of the village: heavy sacks of grain, a barrel from of tools, and several bales of hay.

NPCs. There are no NPCs in the barn, the goats follow and watch the adventurers whenever they are in or near the barn. The milky-eyed doe in particular seems to stay close to one adventurer and follows that adventurer's every move.

FIRE PIT

The pit is the center of daily life with a fire usually lit, even if only with a few flames. A large metal bucket full of fresh water taken from the shore and strained through cheesecloth can usually be found boiling over the fire. A small wooden pavilion with a number of stump stools under it provides a place to rest with minimal protection from the storm.

Elisande: "Da pit es the local for speeching wit the crones. Day always clean the drink. All need the drink."

Searching. The adventurers can acquire clean water and a dozen heavy blocks of wood that might be used for trap or wall building. Knives, needles, and other sharp objects of daily life are prevalent around the flames.

NPCs. Exirsa, Lolmetta, and Rentida, three elderly crones spend their time around the fire boiling water, cleaning fish and gossiping. All are reek of fish and have long stringy grey hair and speak in piercing, voices that pierce even the muted atmosphere of the pouring rain. Along with Warsh, they are the only surviving villagers that were part of the original pact.

The crones are not forthcoming with useful information, but they are willing to converse:

- The crones rarely sleep or leave the fire. There can be found there at all hours of the day. They will not allow the flames to die under any circumstances, claiming a long as the fire burns, so will the village thrive.
- Sometimes they claim to be sisters or other times mother, daughter and grandmother.
- The crones enjoy toying with others, playing mental games by telling half-truths or outlandish tales that just might be true. Believe the lie, doubt the truth.
- They encourage the adventurers to sample their fresh water and cooked food. All of it is perfectly

fine, but they enjoy hinting that it might not be.

Unknown to them, if it is afternoon or later and Verik has not been exposed, the water is **poisoned with greensleep mushroom powder** (onset: 2 hours; effect: level 1 exhaustion until a long rest; DC 10 Constitution negates).

- They also tell fantastical tales of the creature of the woods, carrying away unbelievers, and otherwise being a bogeyman of myth.
- Having been there, they are well aware of the tale of the *Audacity* and while they do not speak of it directly, they hint that they might know more than they are saying if offered the right gifts. Nothing they are offered is ever enough to placate them.
- To convince the crones to aid the adventurers, see "Rallying the Villagers" below.

EXHAUSTION

Some special abilities and environmental hazards, such as starvation and the long-term effects of freezing or scorching temperatures, can lead to a special condition called exhaustion.

Exhaustion is measured in six levels. An effect can cause a creature to suffer one or more levels of exhaustion, as specified in the effects description.

Level Effect

1	Disadvantage on ability checks
2	Speed halved
3	Disadvantage on attack rolls and saving throws
4	Hit point maximum halved
5	Speed reduced to 0
6	Death

As a creature's level of exhaustion increases, the effects worsen. The creature suffers the effect not only of the current level of exhaustion, but also of all the previous levels, so a creature suffering level 2 exhaustion has its speed halved and also has disadvantage on ability checks.

An effect that removes exhaustion reduces its level, with all exhaustion effects disappearing if a creature's exhaustion level is reduced below 1.

Finishing a long rest reduces a creature's exhaustion level by 1, provided that the creature has also ingested some food and drink.

SMOKEHOUSE

The smokehouse is attached to Ulburto's home. Here the fish are smoked and divided up amongst the villagers or taken by Warsh to the mainland to trade for goods the islanders cannot fabricate.

Elisande: "Das ye smokenhouse. Not weal aire, but good eat!"

Searching. The smokehouse is separated into two rooms. The main room is filled with metal hooks covering the walls and ceiling with low burning coals